Of men and blade-wielding battalions
He gathered five hundred horsemen

In Kabul *Laat Jangi* Macnaghten heard the news
That the forces of the brave Amir were drawing near

Loins girded and belt tightened for battle
With Uzbek battalions he was coming to war

Laat Jangi, Macnaghten, Lord of War, commanded *Daaktar* [Dr Percival Lord]
To take forty thousand, with forty commanders

Like a savage tiger, they gave chase
Intent on hunting the brave lion

Roaring and full of passion, they came forth
Driving towards Bamiyan[90]

Dost Mohammad now had at his disposal a small force of under a thousand Uzbek horsemen. Advancing southwards, he managed to drive away the British sepoys of the first British outpost he came across. Shortly afterwards, the Afghan force at Bamiyan under Saleh Mohammad deserted and joined the Amir's army.

Reports of the growing crisis quickly reached Kabul. 'The news put fear into the hearts of the English soldiers,' wrote Mirza 'Ata, 'and even more so into the heart of the King. He was so alarmed by news of the approach of the Amir that he could not sleep, but rather went out at night into the Royal Garden in the lower part of the Bala Hisar, and had a tunnel opened beneath his throne-platform as an escape route.' Whether this was true or not, many British officers sent their families to take shelter in the Bala Hisar, along with their baggage and possessions, while Macnaghten initially refused to send reinforcements to Bamiyan, saying they could not be spared from Kabul. He then sent a series of jittery and paranoid despatches to Simla. 'The Afghans are gunpowder,' he wrote, 'and the Dost is a lighted match . . . We are surrounded by spies.'[91]

But, for all their fears, the cavalry force the Amir had mustered was still insufficient to meet a disciplined Company army in open battle. When British reinforcements were finally sent up to Bamiyan under William Dennie, the two sides met on Friday 18 September. Dost Mohammad had possession of the chain of forts that commanded the entrance of the valley